

Punjabi, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one word at a time

Adhithya Rajasekaran

This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they
are written.

Copyright © Adhithya Rajasekaran. Licensed under Creative Commons
Attribution-ShareAlike 4.0 International (CC BY-SA 4.0). Gurmukhi set
in Noto Sans Gurmukhi (SIL Open Font License).

Preface

This book teaches Punjabi one word at a time, and it teaches each word by taking it apart. It is written for someone starting from zero — who may not read a single Gurmukhi letter — so the script is taught *inside the word lessons themselves*: each word introduces exactly the letters it needs, so you learn to read ਨਮਸਤੇ *and* learn what it means in the same few minutes. (A reader who already reads Gurmukhi simply skims the “letters in this word” notes.)

Punjabi is an **Indo-Aryan** language — descended, like Hindi and Sanskrit, from an old common ancestor — and it is written in **Gurmukhi**, “from the mouth of the Guru,” the script the Sikh Gurus shaped to carry their scriptures. Two threads run through the book: Punjabi’s Sanskrit inheritance (shared with Hindi), and the deep **Perso-Arabic** layer it absorbed on the old road between Persia and India — so “thank you” is both the Sanskritic ਧੰਨਵਾਦ and the Persian ਸ਼ੁਕਰੀਆ. Roots are traced to Sanskrit, to Persian/Arabic, and, where they reach, to the wider family that also gave English its words — every form supplied in full.

How to use this book

Every numbered section is one word, or one small phrase, and takes a few minutes — the length of a queue, an errand, or the walk to the bus. Read them in order the first time through: each section stands on the ones before it, and nothing is used before it has been taught. After that the book becomes reference, and you can open it anywhere.

Say the Punjabi out loud wherever you can. The prompts under *Your turn* are written to be spoken, and saying a word is most of what makes it stay. The questions under *Before you move on* carry their own answers in brackets: cover them, answer from memory, then look.

Nothing here is gated behind the alphabet. Each lesson introduces exactly the letters and sounds its own word needs, so you are reading real

words from the first page rather than drilling a chart. The whole script is gathered in a reference at the back of the book — somewhere to look things up when you are curious, never a chapter to sit through first.

Released under CC BY-SA 4.0 — share it, adapt it, teach from it.

Contents

Preface	iii
1 Greetings	1
1.1 ਸਤਿ ਸ੍ਰੀ ਅਕਾਲ (<i>sat srī akāl</i>) — the Sikh greeting	1
1.2 ਨਮਸਤੇ (<i>namaste</i>) — the shared greeting	2
1.3 ਧੰਨਵਾਦ (<i>dhannavād</i>) — “thank you,” the Sanskrit way	2
1.4 ਸ਼ੁਕਰੀਆ (<i>shukrīā</i>) — “thank you,” the Persian way	3
1.5 ਹਾਂ / ਨਹੀਂ (<i>hāṇ / nahīṇ</i>) — “yes” and “no”	3
1.6 Recap	4
2 Introducing Yourself	5
2.1 ਨਾਂ (<i>nām</i>) — “name,” a word older than Europe	5
2.2 ਮੇਰਾ (<i>merā</i>) — “my”	6
2.3 ਹੈ (<i>hai</i>) — “is,” cousin of English <i>is</i>	6
2.4 ਮੇਰਾ ਨਾਂ...ਹੈ (<i>merā nām ...hai</i>) — “my name is...”	6
2.5 ਤੂੰ and ਤੁਸੀਂ — two forms of “you”	7
2.6 ਕੀ (<i>kī</i>) — “what”	7
2.7 ਤੁਹਾਡਾ ਨਾਂ ਕੀ ਹੈ? (<i>tuhādā nām kī hai</i>) — “what’s your name?”	7
2.8 ਖੁਸ਼ੀ ਹੋਈ (<i>khushī hoī</i>) — “pleased to meet you”	7
2.9 The whole exchange	8
3 How Are You?	9
3.1 ਕਿਵੇਂ (<i>kivēṇ</i>) — “how,” another of the k- questions	9
3.2 ਤੁਸੀਂ ਕਿਵੇਂ ਹੋ? — “how are you?”	9
3.3 ਮੈਂ (<i>maiṇ</i>) — “I”	10
3.4 ਠੀਕ (<i>thīk</i>) — “fine,” and how to answer	10
3.5 ਕੋਈ ਗੱਲ ਨਹੀਂ (<i>koī gall nahīṇ</i>) — “it’s nothing”	10
3.6 The whole exchange	11

4 Farewells	13
4.1 ਫਿਰ (<i>phir</i>) — “again”	13
4.2 ਮਿਲਾਂਗੇ (<i>milāṅge</i>) — “(we) will meet”	13
4.3 ਫਿਰ ਮਿਲਾਂਗੇ (<i>phir milāṅge</i>) — “we’ll meet again”	14
4.4 ਰੱਬ ਰਾਖਾ (<i>rabb rākhā</i>) — “God keep you”	14
4.5 The farewells	14
5 The First Verbs	15
5.1 ਬੋਲਣਾ (<i>bolṇā</i>) — “to speak,” your first full verb	15
5.2 ਮੈਂ ਪੰਜਾਬੀ ਬੋਲਦਾ ਹਾਂ — “I speak Punjabi”	15
5.3 ਰਹਿਣਾ (<i>rahīṇā</i>) — “to live, to stay”	16
5.4 ਕੰਮ ਕਰਨਾ (<i>kamm karnā</i>) — “to work”	16
5.5 Sentences about yourself	16
6 Numbers One to Five	19
6.1 ikk do tinn chār panj	19
6.2 panj · panj	20
7 Six Verbs at the Core	23
7.1 hoṇā	23
7.2 jāṇā	24
7.3 āuṇā	25
7.4 khāṇā	27
7.5 vekhṇā	28
7.6 jāṇṇā	29
The Gurmukhi script (reference)	31

Chapter 1

Greetings

The Punjabi greetings — and, taught through them, how to read the Gurmukhi script and the two faiths and two vocabularies that meet in Punjabi. Each lesson introduces the letters its word needs. *Practice lessons: lessons/PA-C01-*.md.*

1.1 ਸਤਿ ਸ੍ਰੀ ਅਕਾਲ (*sat srī akāl*) — the Sikh greeting

The letters in this word

(If you already read Gurmukhi, skim this.) Gurmukhi runs **left to right** under a top line, and every consonant carries a built-in “a.” ਸ sa, ਤ ta, ਰ ra, ਕ ka, ਲ la. A **vowel sign** changes the vowel (ਾ ā, ਿ i, ੀ ī); a word-initial vowel rides a carrier letter — ਅ is the “a”-carrier. So ਅਕਾਲ = *a-kā-l*, *akāl*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The name **Gurmukhi** means “from the mouth of the *Guru*” (ਗੁਰੂ *gurū* + ਮੁਖ *mukh*, “mouth/face”); the script was standardised by Guru Angad, the second Sikh Guru, to write the scriptures. The greeting itself is a small creed: ਸਤਿ (*sat*, “truth,” from Sanskrit *satya* — the same “being/truth” root behind English *sooth* and *soothsayer*) + ਸ੍ਰੀ (*srī*, an honorific “revered,” from Sanskrit *śrī*, “glory”) + ਅਕਾਲ (*akāl*, “timeless” = *a-* “not” + *kāl* “time/death,” from Sanskrit *kāla*). *Akāl* is a name of God in Sikhism, the Timeless One — so the greeting declares “God is the eternal Truth.”

Why it's said this way

Sat srī akāl is the greeting of Sikhs — said with folded hands, and serving as both hello and goodbye. It is a statement of faith as much as a greeting, which is why it carries such weight. (A Sikh will often answer it by repeating it back.)

1.2 ਨਮਸਤੇ (*namaste*) — the shared greeting**The letters in this word**

New: ਨ *na*, ਮ *ma*, and ਤੇ *te* (ਤ + the *e*-sign ੇ). With ਸ from before, read ਨਮਸਤੇ as *na · ma · s · te*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ਨਮਸਤੇ (*namaste*) = Sanskrit *namas* (“a bow”) + *te* (“to you”) — “I bow to you,” the very same word as Hindi *namaste*. Punjab is home to many communities; *namaste* is the more general, pan-Indian greeting, used across faiths, where *sat srī akāl* is specifically Sikh.

1.3 ਧੰਨਵਾਦ (*dhannavād*) — “thank you,” the Sanskrit way**The letters in this word**

New: ਧ *dha* (breathy *d*), ਵ *va*, ਦ *da*, and the nasal dot ੰ (*tippi*) on ਧੰ *dhami*. Read ਧੰਨਵਾਦ as *dhami · na · vā · d*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ਧੰਨਵਾਦ (*dhannavād*) = Sanskrit *dhanya* (“worthy”) + *vāda* (“a saying”) — the same Sanskrit “thank you” behind Hindi *dhanyavād* and Marathi’s. It is the formal, Sanskritic thanks.

1.4 ਸ਼ੁਕਰੀਆ (*shukrīā*) — “thank you,” the Persian way

The letters in this word

New: ਸ਼ *sha* — the letter ਸ਼ (*sa*) with a dot beneath, a *pair bindi* that marks Perso-Arabic sounds. With ੁ (the *u*-sign) and ੀ, read ਸ਼ੁਕਰੀਆ as *shu · ka · rī · ā*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ਸ਼ੁਕਰੀਆ (*shukrīā*) is *not* Sanskrit — it came through Persian from **Ara-bic** *shukr* (“gratitude”), the *same* Semitic root behind Arabic *shukran*. Punjab sat for centuries on the road between Persia and India, so Punjabi (like Urdu and Hindi) carries **two vocabularies**: Sanskrit (*dhan-navād*) and Perso-Arabic (*shukrīā*). The dot under ਸ਼ is the script’s own record of that borrowing.

1.5 ਹਾਂ / ਨਹੀਂ (*hāṇ* / *nahīṇ*) — “yes” and “no”

The letters in this word

New: ਹ *ha*, and the nasal sign ਂ (*bindi*). ਹਾਂ (*hāṇ*) and ਨਹੀਂ (*nahīṇ*) — both end in a nasalised vowel.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ਹਾਂ (*hāṇ*, “yes”) and ਨਹੀਂ (*nahīṇ*, “no”). The “no” sits on the ancient negative *na-* — the same Proto-Indo-European **ne* behind English **no**, **not**, Latin *non*, and Hindi *nahīṇ*. Punjabi’s “no” and English’s “no” are distant cousins.

1.6 Recap

Punjabi		Meaning
ਸਤਿ ਸ੍ਰੀ ਅਕਾਲ	<i>sat srī akāl</i>	hello / goodbye (Sikh)
ਨਮਸਤੇ	<i>namaste</i>	hello (general)
ਧੰਨਵਾਦ	<i>dhannavād</i>	thank you (Sanskritic)
ਸ਼ੁਕਰੀਆ	<i>shukrīā</i>	thank you (Persian)
ਹਾਂ / ਨਹੀਂ	<i>hāṇ / nahīṇ</i>	yes / no

Two threads run through even these first words: the **Gurmukhi** script, “from the Guru’s mouth,” carrying a Sikh greeting that is a small creed; and Punjabi’s **two vocabularies** — Sanskrit (*dhannavād*) and Perso-Arabic (*shukrīā*), the script itself marking the Persian words with a dot. Next chapter: introducing yourself — *merā nāṇ...* (“my name...”) — and Punjabi’s *tūṇ / tusīṇ* (familiar / respectful “you”).

Chapter 2

Introducing Yourself

Now a first real exchange — giving your name, asking for someone else’s, and saying you’re glad to meet them:

ਮੇਰਾ ਨਾਂ ਮੀਰਾ ਹੈ। (*merā nām Mira hai* — “My name is Mira.”)
ਤੁਹਾਡਾ ਨਾਂ ਕੀ ਹੈ? (*tuhāḍā nām kī hai* — “What is your name?”)

Built the same way as the greetings — each piece taken apart, its letters and root, then assembled. *Practice lessons: lessons/PA-C02-*.md.*

2.1 ਨਾਂ (*nām*) — “name,” a word older than Europe

The letters in this word

ਨ (*na*) + ਾ̃ (the *kannā*, long *ā*) + ਂ (the *bindi*, nasal) → ਨਾਂ (*nām*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ਨਾਂ (*nām*) ← Sanskrit *nāman*, from Proto-Indo-European **h₃nómn*. — the *same* ancient root as English **name**, Latin *nōmen* (English **noun**), and Greek *onoma*. Punjabi *nām* and English *name* are cousins from before either language existed. (Hindi keeps *nām*; Punjabi nasalises the ending.)

2.2 ਮੇਰਾ (*merā*) — “my”

The letters in this word

ਮ (*ma*) + ੇ (the *lāvāṃ*, *e*-sign) → ਮੇ (*me*); ਰ (*ra*) + ਾ (long *ā*) → ਰਾ (*rā*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ਮੇਰਾ (*merā*, “my”) is on the first-person root *ma-* — the same *ma-/me-* behind English **me**, **my**, **mine** and Latin *meus*.

Grammar Lens

“My” agrees with the noun. *merā* (m.), *merī* (f.), *mere* (pl.). *nāṃ* is masculine, so *merā nāṃ*.

2.3 ਹੈ (*hai*) — “is,” cousin of English *is*

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ਹੈ (*hai*, “is”) ← Sanskrit *asti* (“is”), from PIE **h₁es-* — the root of “to be” across the family: English **is**, German *ist*, Latin *est*, Spanish *es*.

Grammar Lens

The verb goes last. Punjabi is *subject-object-verb*: “my name Arun *is*.” The *hai* sits at the end, where English puts “is” in the middle.

2.4 ਮੇਰਾ ਨਾਂ ...ਹੈ (*merā nāṃ ...hai*) — “my name is...”

ਮੇਰਾ (my) + ਨਾਂ (name) + name + ਹੈ (is) = “my name is...” *Merā nāṃ Arun hai*. The verb-frame comes last, as always.

2.5 ਤੂੰ and ਤੁਸੀਂ (*tūṃ*, *tusīṃ*) — “you,” familiar and respectful

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ਤੂੰ (*tūṃ*, familiar “you”) ← Sanskrit *tvam*, from PIE *tū — the same root as English archaic **thou**, Latin *tū*, French *tu*. ਤੁਸੀਂ (*tusīṃ*, respectful) is grammatically plural — courtesy-by-plural, like French *vous*.

Grammar Lens

Two levels: *tūṃ* (familiar) / *tusīṃ* (respectful, also plural). For a first meeting, always *tusīṃ*.

2.6 ਕੀ (*kī*) — “what”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ਕੀ (*kī*, “what”) ← the interrogative stem *ka-*, from PIE *k^wo- — the same root behind English **wh-** words and Latin *qu-*. Punjabi’s questions nearly all start with *k-*: *kī* (what), *kaun* (who), *kad* (when), *kithē* (where), *kivēṃ* (how).

2.7 ਤੁਹਾਡਾ ਨਾਂ ਕੀ ਹੈ? (*tuhāḍā nām kī hai*) — “what’s your name?”

ਤੁਹਾਡਾ (*tuhāḍā*, “your,” the respectful possessive) + ਨਾਂ (name) + ਕੀ (what) + ਹੈ (is) = “**your name what is?**” — verb last, the question-word dropped into the object slot. The familiar “your” is *terā* (from *tūṃ*).

2.8 ਖੁਸ਼ੀ ਹੋਈ (*khushī hoī*) — “pleased to meet you”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The full phrase is ਤੁਹਾਨੂੰ ਮਿਲ ਕੇ ਖੁਸ਼ੀ ਹੋਈ (*tuhānūṃ mil ke khushī hoī*) — “having met you, happiness happened.” The key word ਖੁਸ਼ੀ (*khushī*, “happiness”) is **not** Sanskrit — it is **Persian** (*khush*, “happy”), marked by

two pair-bindis (ਖ਼, ਸ਼). So introducing yourself draws on Punjabi's **two vocabularies**: Sanskrit (*nām̐*, *hai*) and Perso-Arabic (*khushī*).

2.9 The whole exchange

Punjabi	English
ਮੇਰਾ ਨਾਂ ਮੀਰਾ ਹੈ।	My name is Mira.
ਤੁਹਾਡਾ ਨਾਂ ਕੀ ਹੈ?	What's your name?
ਮੇਰਾ ਨਾਂ ਅਰੁਣ ਹੈ।	My name is Arun.
ਤੁਹਾਨੂੰ ਮਿਲ ਕੇ ਖੁਸ਼ੀ ਹੋਈ।	Pleased to meet you.

Every atom traced: *nām̐* (Sanskrit *nāman*, English *name*), *merā* (root *ma-*, English *my*), *hai* (Sanskrit *asti*, English *is*), *kī* (root *ka-*, English *what*), and *khushī* (Persian — the second vocabulary). Next chapter: *tusīm kivēm ho?* (“how are you?”) — the responding cycle.

Chapter 3

How Are You?

After the name comes the exchange everyone actually has:

ਤੁਸੀਂ ਕਿਵੇਂ ਹੋ? (*tusīṃ kivēṃ ho* — “How are you?”)
ਮੈਂ ਠੀਕ ਹਾਂ, ਧੰਨਵਾਦ। (*maiṃ ṭhīk hām, dhannavād* — “I’m fine, thank you.”)

Practice lessons: lessons/PA-C03-.md.*

3.1 ਕਿਵੇਂ (*kivēṃ*) — “how,” another of the k- questions

The letters in this word

ਕ (*ka*) + ਿ (the *sihārī*, *i*-sign, before) → ਕਿ; ਵ (*va*) + ੇ + ਂ → ਵੇਂ. Read *kivēṃ*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ਕਿਵੇਂ (*kivēṃ*, “how”) is from the interrogative stem *ka-*, PIE **k^wo-* — the same root behind English **wh-** and Latin *qu-*. Punjabi’s questions nearly all begin with *k-*: *kī*, *kaṃ*, *kad*, *kithē*, *kivēṃ*.

3.2 ਤੁਸੀਂ ਕਿਵੇਂ ਹੋ? — “how are you?”

ਤੁਸੀਂ (*tusīṃ*, respectful “you”) + ਕਿਵੇਂ (“how”) + ਹੋ (*ho*, “are”) — “you how are?”, the verb last. The copula set: *maiṃ hām* (I am), *tūṃ haiṃ* (you are, fam.), *oh hai* (he is), *tusīṃ ho* (you are, resp.).

Grammar Lens

Match the “you” to the verb: *tusīm ...ho* (respectful), *tūṃ kivēm haiṃ?* (familiar).

3.3 ਮੈਂ (*maiṃ*) — “I”**The word, taken apart — its roots and family**

ਮੈਂ (*maiṃ*, “I”) is on the first-person root *ma-* — the same root as *merā* (“my”) and behind English **me**, **my**. It takes the copula ਹਾਂ (*hām*, “am”). Watch the homophone: this *hām* (“am”) is spelled like the *hām* (“yes”) of Chapter 1 — context tells them apart.

3.4 ਠੀਕ (*ṭhīk*) — “fine,” and how to answer**The letters in this word**

ਠ (*ṭha*, a **retroflex** *th*) + ੀ (long *ī*) + ਕ (*ka*) → ਠੀਕ.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ਠੀਕ (*ṭhīk*) means “correct, right, fine, OK” — a native Indian word (shared with Hindi/Urdu), no European cousin. Put it together: ਮੈਂ ਠੀਕ ਹਾਂ (*maiṃ ṭhīk hām*) — “I am fine,” verb last.

3.5 ਕੋਈ ਗੱਲ ਨਹੀਂ (*koī gall nahīṃ*) — “it’s nothing”**The word, taken apart — its roots and family**

ਕੋਈ ਗੱਲ ਨਹੀਂ literally “[**there is**] **no matter**” — *koī* (“any”) + *ਗੱਲ* (*gall*, “matter, talk”) + *ਨਹੀਂ* (*nahīṃ*, “not”). It serves as “it’s nothing / you’re welcome.” *Gall* is a warm native Punjabi word; *nahīṃ* you met in Chapter 1 — the ancient negative *na-*, PIE **ne*, behind English **no**, **not**, **none**.

3.6 The whole exchange

Punjabi	English
ਤੁਸੀਂ ਕਿਵੇਂ ਹੋ?	How are you?
ਮੈਂ ਠੀਕ ਹਾਂ, ਧੰਨਵਾਦ।	I'm fine, thank you.
ਕੋਈ ਗੱਲ ਨਹੀਂ।	It's nothing / you're welcome.

Roots banked: *kivēm* (the *k*- questions), *maiṃ* (*ma*-, English *me*), *thīk* (native), *nahīm* (PIE *ne, English *no*). Next chapter: the farewells.

Chapter 4

Farewells

Chapter 1 gave you the formal ਸਤਿ ਸ੍ਰੀ ਅਕਾਲ (*sat srī akāl*), which doubles as a goodbye. Real days end more warmly:

ਫਿਰ ਮਿਲਾਂਗੇ! (*phir milāṅge* — “We’ll meet again!”)

Practice lessons: lessons/PA-CO4-.md.*

4.1 ਫਿਰ (*phir*) — “again”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ਫਿਰ (*phir*) means “again, then” — a native Indo-Aryan adverb (the same word as Hindi *phir*) with no tidy English cognate, but a familiar job: it turns a parting into a promise.

4.2 ਮਿਲਾਂਗੇ (*milāṅge*) — “(we) will meet”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ਮਿਲਾਂਗੇ (*milāṅge*, “we will meet”) is the future of ਮਿਲਣਾ (*milṇā*, “to meet”), from Sanskrit *mil-* (“to join”) — the root of *milāp* (“a meeting”). The ending *-āṅge* is the plural future.

Grammar Lens

The future is an ending. *mil-* + *-āṅge* → *milāṅge* — no helper like English “will.”

4.3 ਫਿਰ ਮਿਲਾਂਗੇ (*phir milāṅge*) — “we’ll meet again”

ਫਿਰ (again) + ਮਿਲਾਂਗੇ (we will meet) = “**we’ll meet again**” — the everyday, hopeful goodbye, where *sat srī akāl* is the formal one. It is the same “promise of return” the whole subcontinent prefers (Hindi *phir milenge*, Bengali *āshī*, Tamil *pōy varugirēṇ*).

4.4 ਰੱਬ ਰਾਖਾ (*rabb rākhā*) — “God keep you”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ਰੱਬ ਰਾਖਾ means “[may] God [be your] keeper” — ਰੱਬ (*rabb*, “God”) + ਰਾਖਾ (*rākhā*, “protector,” from *rakhṇā* ← Sanskrit *rakṣ-*, “to guard”). The word for God, *rabb*, is itself **Arabic** (*rabb*, “lord”) — so this most Punjabi of farewells fuses an Arabic name for God with a Sanskrit verb of keeping: the two vocabularies in one blessing.

4.5 The farewells

Punjabi		Register
ਸਤਿ ਸ੍ਰੀ ਅਕਾਲ	<i>sat srī akāl</i>	formal (Sikh greeting-goodbye)
ਫਿਰ ਮਿਲਾਂਗੇ	<i>phir milāṅge</i>	everyday, “we’ll meet again”
ਰੱਬ ਰਾਖਾ	<i>rabb rākhā</i>	a blessing, “God keep you”

Roots banked: *milāṅge* (*mil-* “to join”), *rabb* (Arabic “God”) + *rākhā* (Sanskrit *rakṣ-* “to protect”). Next chapter: the first real verbs — *māṁ* *panjābī boldā hāṁ*.

Chapter 5

The First Verbs

Until now, “to be.” Now verbs that *act* — and sentences that move:

ਮੈਂ ਪੰਜਾਬੀ ਬੋਲਦਾ ਹਾਂ। (*maiṁ pañjābī boldā hāṁ* — “I speak Punjabi.”)

Practice lessons: lessons/PA-C05-.md.*

5.1 ਬੋਲਣਾ (*bolṇā*) — “to speak,” your first full verb

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ਬੋਲਣਾ (*bolṇā*, “to speak”) is a native Indo-Aryan verb (the same word as Hindi *bolnā*). Its ending -ਣਾ (*-ṇā*) is the point: **every** Punjabi infinitive ends in *-ṇā/-nā* — *bol-ṇā* “to speak,” *mil-ṇā* “to meet,” *rakh-ṇā* “to keep.” Strip it and you have the **stem** (*bol-*).

Grammar Lens

Stem + ending. *bol-dā* (speaking, m.), *bol-dī* (f.), *bol* (speak!). Every tense builds on a stem like this.

5.2 ਮੈਂ ਪੰਜਾਬੀ ਬੋਲਦਾ ਹਾਂ — “I speak Punjabi”

ਮੈਂ (I) + ਪੰਜਾਬੀ (*pañjābī*, the object) + ਬੋਲਦਾ (speak, m.) + ਹਾਂ (am) — “I Punjabi speaking am,” verb-frame last.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The name ਪੰਜਾਬੀ (*pañjābī*) is **Persian**: ਪੰਜ (*pañj*, “five” — a distant cousin of English **five**, Latin *quinque*, Greek *pente*) + ਆਬ (*āb*, “water, river”) = “the [language] of the **five rivers**,” for the five great rivers of the Punjab. The very name is a Persian geography lesson.

Grammar Lens

The present habitual is gendered. A man: *maiṃ pañjābī boldā hāṃ*; a woman: *...boldī hāṃ*. The *-dā/-dī* marks the speaker’s gender.

5.3 ਰਹਿਣਾ (*rahiṇā*) — “to live, to stay”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ਰਹਿਣਾ (*rahiṇā*, “to live, remain, stay”), from Sanskrit *rah-* (“to remain,” the same as Hindi *rahnā*): *maiṃ Amritsar rahindā hāṃ* (“I live in Amritsar”). Punjabi, like Hindi, uses **postpositions** (*vic*, “in”) — often dropped with a place-name — where English uses prepositions.

5.4 ਕੰਮ ਕਰਨਾ (*kamm karnā*) — “to work”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ਕਰਨਾ (*karnā*, “to do, make”) is from Sanskrit *kr-* (“to do”), PIE **k^wer-* — the root you met in Chapter 1’s *namaskār* (*namas* + *kār*, “the *making* of a bow”) and in *karma*. Punjabi builds compounds as **noun + ਕਰਨਾ**: ਕੰਮ ਕਰਨਾ (*kamm karnā*, “work-do” = “to work”), *gall karnā* (“to have a chat”). So *maiṃ kamm kardā hāṃ* = “I work.”

5.5 Sentences about yourself

Punjabi	English
ਮੈਂ ਪੰਜਾਬੀ ਬੋਲਦਾ/ਬੋਲਦੀ ਹਾਂ।	I speak Punjabi.
ਮੈਂ ਅੰਮ੍ਰਿਤਸਰ ਰਹਿੰਦਾ/ਰਹਿੰਦੀ ਹਾਂ।	I live in Amritsar.
ਮੈਂ ਕੰਮ ਕਰਦਾ/ਕਰਦੀ ਹਾਂ।	I work.

Three verbs, one engine: a stem, the $-dā/-dī$ that agrees in gender, and the copula that agrees in person — the verb always last. Roots banked: *bolḥā*, *rahḥā* (*rah-* “remain”), *karnā* (*kṛ* — root of *namaskār*, *karma*), and *panjābī* (*panj* “five” + *āb* “river”). From here, Punjabi’s sentences only grow.

Chapter 6

Numbers One to Five

6.1 ਇੱਕ, ਦੋ, ਤਿੰਨ, ਚਾਰ, ਪੰਜ — one to five

Four of these are new. The fifth you have known since **Chapter 5** — you just didn't know it was a number.

You'll want to know: the five

	Punjabi	said
1	ਇੱਕ	<i>ikk</i>
2	ਦੋ	<i>do</i>
3	ਤਿੰਨ	<i>tinn</i>
4	ਚਾਰ	<i>chār</i>
5	ਪੰਜ	<i>panj</i>

This is **Gurmukhi**, not Devanagari — a related but distinct script. It does have a top line like Devanagari's, so words hang from a bar in the same way.

Two marks worth telling apart, because they look similar and do different jobs:

- ੱ — the **addak**, on *ikk*. It **doubles the following consonant**.
- ੰ — the **tippi**, on *tinn* and *panj*. It marks a **nasal**.

(So *tinn*'s double *n* is not the addak's doing — that word is spelled with a nasal mark, and the doubling is in the pronunciation.)

What you’ve built: ਪੰਜ as a number

Chapter 5 took the name ਪੰਜਾਬੀ (*panjābī*) apart for you: Persian ਪੰਜ *panj*, “five,” plus ਆਬ *āb*, “water” — the language **of the five rivers**.

You learned *panj* there as a piece of a place-name. Here it arrives as what it actually is: **the number five**, an ordinary word you will count with.

The next prerequisite-ordered lesson explains an important twist: Punjabi’s numeral and the Persian word reached the same *panj* shape independently.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “ikk, do, tinn, chār, panj”
- the two marks — “**addak** doubles, **tippi** nasalises”
- the Ch. 5 callback — “**panj** + **āb** = five rivers”

Before you move on

Count to five in Punjabi. (*Ikk, do, tinn, chār, panj.*) What script is this? (**Gurmukhi** — related to Devanagari, and it has a top line too.) What does ੱ and ੰ each do? (**Addak** doubles the following consonant; **tippi** marks a nasal.) Chapter 5 told you *panjābī* means “of the five rivers.” What has changed now? (***Panj* is a number you can count with, not just a piece of a name.**) Next: learn why Punjabi and Persian both say *panj*.

6.2 Why two branches both arrived at *panj*

Say “five” in Punjabi. (*Panj.*) Where did Chapter 5 first show that shape? (Inside Persian *panj* + *āb*, “five waters.”)

What you’ve built: the surprising family comparison

language	“five”
Sanskrit	<i>pañca</i>
Hindi	<i>pāñch</i>
Bengali	<i>pāch</i>
Gujarati	<i>pāch</i>
Punjabi	<i>pañj</i>
Persian	<i>pañj</i>

The neighbours keep a **-ch** shape. Punjabi matches Persian **-j**, but the obvious borrowing story is wrong.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Punjabi *pañj* is inherited from Sanskrit *pañca*. North-western Indo-Aryan regularly **voiced a stop after a nasal**, turning *-ñc-* into *-ñj-*. Punjabi **pañjāh** “fifty” (from Sanskrit *pañcāśat*) makes the rule visible; Hindi **pacās** shows the same source changing differently.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Persian independently voiced ancestral *č* to *j*: Iranian *panč* became *pañj*. Two Indo-Iranian branches therefore reached the same shape separately:

branch	path
Punjabi	Sanskrit <i>pañca</i> → nasal-triggered <i>-ñj-</i>
Persian	Iranian <i>panč</i> → voiced <i>pañj</i>

This is **convergence, not borrowing**. The **place-name** *Punjab* is Persian; Punjabi’s look-alike **numeral** is inherited from Sanskrit.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- Punjabi’s path and proof — Sanskrit *pañca* → post-nasal *-ñj-*; *pañjāh* / *pacās*
- Persian’s path and the conclusion — *panč* → *pañj* independently; convergence, not borrowing
- Persian place-name, inherited Punjabi number

Before you move on

Borrowed from Persian? (No: Punjabi *pañj* inherits Sanskrit *pañca*.)
What made *-nj-*? (A post-nasal stop voiced.) Evidence? (*Panjāh* / *pacās*.)
Persian's path? (Its ancestral *č* voiced separately.) In *Punjab*,
what is Persian? (The place-name; Punjabi's number is homegrown.)

Chapter 7

Six Verbs at the Core

7.1 ਹੋਣਾ — “to be,” and the two old verbs braided inside it

You have been saying ਹੈ *hai*, “is,” since Chapter 2. Here is the verb it belongs to — and it sounds nothing like it.

You’ll want to know first — one word

ਹੋਣਾ — *hoṇā* — to be

Four shapes, hanging from the top line: ਹ *h*, with the ੋ sign on it for *o*; then ਣ, an *n* made with the tongue tip curled back; then ਾ for long *ā*. It reads *ho-ṇā*.

The ending -ਣਾ -*ṇā* is how Punjabi names a verb — the same ending that sat on *bolṇā*. English names a verb by putting a word in front of it, *to be*; Punjabi puts an ending on the back and never uses a separate word. Take that ending off and what remains is the **stem: ho-**.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

hoṇā comes from Sanskrit *bhavati*, “becomes,” built on the root *bhū-*. Middle Indo-Aryan softened that *bh-* to *h-*, so *bhavati* thinned to *hoi* and then to **hoṇā**.

The root is Indo-European, **b^huH-*, “grow, become.” English keeps it in **be** and **been**, and — by way of “the place where one dwells” — in **build**, **booth**, and **bower**. Latin held it as *fuī* “I was” and *futūrus*, which English borrowed as **future**. Greek held it as *phúsis* “nature,” which English borrowed as **physics**.

Grammar Lens: one verb, two roots

Chapter 2 traced है *hai* to a different Sanskrit verb altogether — *asti*, “is,” the root behind English **is**, Latin *est*, German *ist*. So Punjabi’s “to be” is **two ancient verbs braided into one**: the name and the stem come from *bhū-*, the everyday present tense comes from *as-*.

English braids the very same two, at the very same seam, and nobody notices: *am*, *is*, *are* belong to the *as-* verb; *be*, *being*, *been* belong to the *b^huH-* verb.

Your turn

- *Say it*: **hoṇā** — to be
- *Strip*: **hoṇā** minus **-ṇā** leaves the stem **ho-**
- *Connect*: **hoṇā** ← *bhavati* → English **be**
- *Connect*: **hai** ← *asti* → English **is**

Before you move on

Which ending names a Punjabi verb, and what is left of *hoṇā* once you take it off? (**-ṇā**; the stem **ho-**.) And why do *hoṇā* and *hai* not resemble each other at all? (They are two different ancient verbs braided into one — the *bhū-* verb and the *as-* verb, exactly as English braids *be* with *is*.)

7.2 ਜਾਣਾ — “to go,” and a sound law you can run yourself

Name the ending that turns a Punjabi stem into the verb’s plain name. (**-ਣਾ** *-ṇā*.) Here is the second verb to wear it.

You’ll want to know first — one word

ਜਾਣਾ — *jāṇā* — to go

ਜ *j*, then ਾ *long ā*, then ਣ — the curled-back *ṇ* you already met inside *hoṇā* — then ਾ *again*. Nothing new to decode. Strip the **-ਣਾ** and the stem is **jā-**.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

jāṇā is Sanskrit *yāti*, “goes,” on the root *yā-*, “travel.” The *y* became a *j*, and that was not an accident about this one word. Early Indo-Aryan turned **every** initial *y-* into *j-* on the way to Punjabi, and the change is regular enough to run backwards yourself:

- Sanskrit *yoga* → Punjabi **jog**
- Sanskrit *yuvan* “young” → Punjabi **javān**
- Sanskrit *yamunā*, the river → Punjabi **Jamnā**

So a Sanskrit word beginning *y-* is very often a Punjabi word you half know already, hiding behind a *j*.

The root itself is Indo-European, **yeh₂-*, “to go, travel” — the same verb as Lithuanian *jóti*, “to ride.” It is one of the rare cases where English inherited nothing usable, so the prize here is the rule, not the cousin.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **jāṇā** — to go
- *Strip:* **jāṇā** minus **-ṇā** leaves the stem **jā-**
- *Run the rule:* *yoga* → **jog**, *yuvan* → **javān**, *yamunā* → **Jamnā**
- *Connect:* **jāṇā** ← Sanskrit *yāti*, “goes”

Before you move on

Which Sanskrit verb is *jāṇā*, and what happened to its first sound? (*Yāti*, “goes”; the *y-* became *j-*.) Give one more word the same change caught. (*Jog*, *javān*, or *Jamnā*.)

7.3 ਆਉਣਾ — “to come,” which is “go” pointed back at you

You can say *jāṇā*, “to go.” Its opposite is not a different verb. It is the same verb with one small piece stuck on the front.

You'll want to know first — one word

ਆਉਣਾ — *āuṇā* — to come

ਆ is a whole syllable on its own, long *ā*: a Punjabi word cannot start with a bare vowel sign, so a vowel that opens a word rides a carrier letter. Then ਊ for *u*, then the familiar ਣ ending. It reads *ā-u-ṇā*, three beats. The stem is *ā-*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

āuṇā goes back to Sanskrit *ā-gacchati*, “comes.” Take that apart and it is the prefix *ā-*, “toward, hither,” sitting on the verb **gam-**, “go.” Punjabi’s “come” is literally *go-toward-me*, and the *g* wore away over the centuries until only the rounded *-u-* was left of it.

That prefix is a tool, not a one-off: Punjabi keeps *ā-* in the sense of motion **toward** the speaker, the same job English does with a separate word.

And **gam-** is the good part. It is Indo-European **g^wem-*, “to step, go” — and English inherited it straight down the Germanic line as **come**. Latin took the same root as *venīre*, which English then borrowed back many times over: **advent**, **invent**, **convene**, **venue**, **event**, **revenue**, **intervene**, **souvenir**. Greek took it as *baínein*, “to step,” giving English **base**, **basis**, and **acrobat**.

So when a Punjabi speaker says *ā*, the second syllable of that word is the same ancient step as your own *come*.

Your turn

- *Say it*: **jāṇā** to go, then **āuṇā** to come
- *Split*: **ā-** toward, plus **gam-** go
- *Connect*: *gam-* ← **g^wem-* → English **come**, **advent**, **acrobat**

Before you move on

What two pieces are inside *āuṇā*? (The prefix *ā-*, “toward,” and the old verb *gam-*, “go.”) Which everyday English verb is that second piece? (**Come**.)

7.4 ਖਾਣਾ — “to eat,” and the tone hiding one letter away

This verb is easy. Its neighbour in the alphabet is the strangest thing in the whole language, and this is where you meet it.

You’ll want to know first — one word

ਖਾਣਾ — *khāṇā* — to eat

ਖ is *kh*: a *k* with a puff of breath after it, as in English *back-hand* said fast. Then ਾ, then the ending ਣਾ. The stem is **khā-**.

It comes straight from Sanskrit *khādati*, “chews, eats.” No English cousin has been securely traced from that root, and that is fine — the prize in this word is its **sound**.

The letters in this word

Gurmukhi keeps its consonants in rows of five. The *k*-row runs ਕ *ka*, ਖ *kha*, ਗ *ga*, ਘ — and that fourth letter was once *gha*, a *g* said with a breathy voice.

Punjabi lost those breathy-voiced sounds. It did **not** lose the words. When ਘ *gh* starts a word it is now said as a plain *k*, and everything the old consonant carried moved onto the vowel as a **low, rising pitch**.

Same elsewhere in the word, in mirror image: the pitch falls instead.

That leaves pairs which are spelled differently and pronounced identically, apart from the tune:

Punjabi	said
ਘੋੜਾ horse	<i>kòṛā</i> , pitch dipping then rising
ਕੋੜਾ whip	<i>koṛā</i> , pitch level

Two words, one string of consonants and vowels, and the only difference is music. That makes Punjabi the one major Indo-Aryan language with **tone** — Hindi, Urdu, Bengali, Gujarati, and Marathi have nothing like it.

Your ਖਾਣਾ is safe: ਖ *kh* is voiceless, it never had the breathy voice, so it never traded anything for a tone. *Khāṇā* is said flat.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- **khāṇā** — to eat — flat, no tune
- the pair — *kòṛā* horse, dipping; then *koṛā* whip, level
- the rule — the old breathy *gh* went and left a pitch behind

Before you move on

What separates *kòṛā* “horse” from *koṛā* “whip”? (Pitch alone — the first dips and rises.) Where did that pitch come from? (From **ਘ**, an old breathy *gh* that stopped being breathy.) And does *khāṇā* carry one? (No — **ਖ** *kh* has no voice to lose.)

7.5 ਵੇਖਣਾ — “to see,” a verb built out of the eye itself

The **ਖ** *kh* you learned in *khāṇā* turns up again here, in the middle of a word this time. Same puff of breath, same flat pitch.

You’ll want to know first — one word

ਵੇਖਣਾ — *vekhṇā* — to see, to look

ਵ *v*, with the ੇ sign on it for *e*; then **ਖ** *kh*; then the ending ਣਾ. It reads *vekh-ṇā*, and the stem is **vekh-**.

Punjabi also says ਦੇਖਣਾ *dekhṇā* for the same thing, which is the form Hindi settled on. One word, two front consonants, both alive in Punjabi — *vekhṇā* is the more homely, more Punjabi-sounding of the two.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

vekhṇā comes from Sanskrit *prekṣate*, “looks at” — the prefix *pra-*, “forth,” on the verb *īkṣ-*, “see.” And *īkṣ-* is built on *akṣi*, the Sanskrit word for the **eye**. Punjabi’s verb for seeing is, underneath, the organ you do it with.

That noun is Indo-European, **h₃ekʷ-*, and English is full of it. Inherited plainly: **eye** — and **window**, borrowed from Norse *vindauga*, a “wind-eye,” the hole that let the smoke out. Borrowed from Latin *oculus*: **ocular**, **binoculars**, **inoculate**. Borrowed from Greek *ōps* and *optikós*: **optic**, **optician**, **autopsy** (seeing for oneself), **synopsis**, **myopia**. So *vekhṇā*, *eye*, *window*, and *autopsy* are four settlements of one very

old word for the thing in your head.

Your turn

- *Say it:* **vekhṇā** — to see — then its twin **dekhṇā**
- *Strip:* **vekhṇā** minus **-ṇā** leaves **vekh-**
- *Connect:* *īkṣ-* ← **h₃ek^w-* → English **eye**, **optic**, **window**

Before you move on

What noun is hiding inside *vekhṇā*? (The **eye** — Sanskrit *akṣi*, behind the verb *īkṣ-*.) Name two English words off that root. (Any of **eye**, **window**, **ocular**, **optic**, **autopsy**.) And what is the Hindi-shaped twin of this verb? (*Dekhṇā*.)

7.6 ਜਾਣਨਾ — “to know,” one letter from “to go”

Run the five you have — *hoṇā*, *jāṇā*, *āṇā*, *khāṇā*, *vekhṇā* — and pull the stem off each one. The sixth is the closest of them all to English.

You’ll want to know first — one word

ਜਾਣਨਾ — *jāṇnā* — **to know**

ਜ *j*, ਾ long *ā*, then ਣ — the curled-back *ṇ* — and then a second, different *n*: ਨ, made with the tongue on the teeth. Then ਾ. Both are pronounced, one after the other: *jāṇ-nā*, held long across the seam, the way English does in *thin-ness*.

That second letter is the whole difference between ਜਾਣਾ *jāṇā* “to go” and ਜਾਣਨਾ *jāṇnā* “to know.” The stem here is **jāṇ-**, and because it already ends in the curled-back *ṇ*, the infinitive shows up in its other shape, plain -ਨਾ *-nā*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

jāṇnā continues Sanskrit *jānāti*, on the root *jñā-*, “know.” Note what that means for the rule from *jāṇā*: these two Punjabi verbs both open with ਜ *j*, but from different sources — *jāṇā*’s *j* was a Sanskrit *y*, while *jāṇnā*’s was already there, in *jñā-*.

That root is Indo-European **ǵneh₃*-, and English is stuffed with it. Down the Germanic line: **know**, **knowledge**, **can** (once “to know how”), **cunning**, **ken**, and **uncouth**, which is “un-known.” Borrowed from Latin (*g*)*nōscere*: **notice**, **note**, **notion**, **cognition**, **recognize**, **acquaint**, **narrate**, and **ignore** — “not to know.” Borrowed from Greek *gnōsis*: **diagnosis**, **prognosis**, **agnostic**.

Your turn

- *Contrast*: **jāṇā** to go, then **jāñnā** to know, holding the long *n*
- *Run all six*: *hoṇā*, *jāṇā*, *āṇā*, *khāṇā*, *vekhṇā*, *jāñnā*, stripping each stem
- *Say it*: the two sources — *jāṇā*’s *j* from *yā*-, *jāñnā*’s from *jñā*-
- *Say it*: not one of the six carries a tone — every stem is flat
- *Connect*: *jñā*- → English **know**, **notice**, **diagnosis**

Before you move on

What single written mark separates *jāṇā* from *jāñnā*? (A second *n*, the dental ढ, held long in speech.) Where did each verb’s *j* come from? (*Jāṇā*’s from a Sanskrit *y*-; *jāñnā*’s from *jñā*-.) And which English verb is the very same word as *jāñnā*? (**Know**.)

The Gurmukhi script — a reference

Not to be read before the lessons — they teach reading through real words.
This page gathers the system.

The three facts

1. **Consonants carry a built-in “a.”** ਕ ka, ਨ na, ਮ ma — written left to right under a connecting top line.
2. **A vowel sign changes it.** ਾ ā (ਕਾ kā), ਿ i, ਿੀ ī, ੁ u, ੁ ੁ, ੇ e, ੋ o. A *bindi* ਿ or *tippi* ਿ nasalises the vowel.
3. **Word-initial vowels ride a carrier.** Three bearer letters — ਓ (u-series), ਅ (a-series), ਏ (i-series) — hold a vowel that starts a word: ਅ + nothing = a, ਆ = ā.

Worth flagging

- **The *pair bindi* (a dot beneath).** It marks Perso-Arabic sounds Punjabi borrowed: ਸ sh, ਖ x/kh, ਜ z, ਫ f, ਗ g. The script literally *annotates* its loanwords.
- **Tone.** Punjabi is unusual among Indian languages in being *tonal* — certain letters (the old voiced-aspirates ਅ ਝ ਢ ਧ ਢ) now trigger a low or high tone on the syllable. You will pick this up by ear; the lessons flag it only where it changes a word.

Gurmukhi and the Punjabi story

Gurmukhi means “from the mouth of the Guru”: the second Sikh Guru, Angad, shaped it in the 16th century to write the community’s teachings.

Punjabi is **Indo-Aryan** (like Hindi, Marathi, Bengali — all from Sanskrit), spoken across Punjab in India and Pakistan; in Pakistan it is more often written in a Perso-Arabic script (*Shahmukhi*), a mirror of Punjabi's own two inheritances. The lessons trace both — the Sanskrit and the Persian.